

POWER OF THE UNKNOWN

“We can foresee vulnerability of an environment”

NASSIM NICHOLAS TALEB PHILOSOPHER AND EXPERT ON RISK

I am a little fed up of *The Black Swan*. I am tired of *The Black Swan* after three-and-a-half years, you understand. So, I'm going to talk about that and also about many other things. I have been working on a book which is a follow up to *The Black Swan*. The book will be called *Tinkering* and will deal with “How to live in a world we don't understand”. It is a very simple book except that the simplicity of the title and the idea makes it a very complicated one to write if you see it the other way.

So let me start now by making you a little uncomfortable, just a little bit, and then things will get better as we go on. The wheel was discovered not far from where I am from in Lebanon—half way between Lebanon and Babylon. We know the wheel changed the world. It was discovered somewhere around 6,000 years ago. Now juxtapose this with the trolley bag. So why did it take over 6,000 years for this change to happen? Did you know that the Mexicans, when they built pyramids, had a wheel but didn't think of wheelbarrows?

Essentially, it is hard to predict which technology is going

to come and dominate. Ronald Reagan was an actor who had a change of career and became the most powerful man of the world. He hated taxes and he hated the Soviet Union. So this obsessive disorder with the Soviet Union made him spend a lot of money to fund Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency, a unit of the Pentagon that developed the Internet because of which I am here and because of which Bangalore is famous. But his intention was not to help Bangalore, or to create a big technological centre. He just wanted to destroy the Russians. So, realise that technology is very hard to predict and is mostly dominated by the unexpected implementations. You don't see them coming and the problem is that you can't predict them. If you can't predict them you can't predict history. No matter how many white swans you have seen, it doesn't tell you anything about the possibility of a black swan. This is how I define a black swan event. Unlike the bird, it doesn't have feathers. It has consequences, like the invention of the wheel or the Internet.

My contention is that we cannot see these things coming,

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